

HIKITA'S $\star$ -PRODUCT ON SYMMETRIC FUNCTIONS: PIERI RULES, DOMINANCE SUPPORT, AND THE $(s - 1)$ -ADIC VALUATION

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ABSTRACT. Hikita introduced a two-parameter deformation $\star$ of the product of symmetric functions, obtained by transporting the ordinary product through the level-one polynomial representation of the affine Hecke algebra. We give an explicit rule for $e_k \star (e_{a_1} \cdots e_{a_\ell})$ for all k and ℓ , in generating-function form; its case $\ell = 1$ is a Pieri rule for $e_k \star e_r$ generalising Hikita's rule for $e_1 \star e_r$. Writing $e_{\lambda_1} \star \cdots \star e_{\lambda_\ell} = \sum_{\mu} c_{\lambda\mu}(s, t) e_{\mu}$, we show that $c_{\lambda\mu}$ is supported exactly on the dominance up-set of λ with s -adic valuation $n(\mu)$, and that the $(s - 1)$ -adic valuation of $c_{\lambda\mu}$ is $\ell(\lambda) - \kappa(\lambda, \mu)$, where κ is the maximal number of blocks into which λ and μ split compatibly. Leading coefficients factor over blocks into connected pieces; for a full merge the connected piece is a connected-graph cumulant. The coefficients are invariant, up to a power of s , under complementation in a box, and all second-order leading coefficients are given in closed form via a residue formula for Green polynomials at two-part classes.

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1. INTRODUCTION

Hikita [Hik25] defined a commutative, associative product $\star$ on symmetric functions over $\mathbb{Q}(q, t)$ by transporting the ordinary product through the level-one polynomial representation of the affine Hecke algebra. We write $s := q^{-1}$. At $s = 1$, $\star$ is the ordinary product. Hikita's Pieri rule [Hik25, Thm. 3.12] reads, in our normalisation,

$$e_1 \star e_r = (1 - s)[r + 1]_t e_{r+1} + s e_1 e_r.$$

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Di Francesco and Kedem [DFK19, §8.3] observed that the associated t -deformed graded characters lose Schur positivity at generic t . This paper is about the structure that survives: explicit multiplication rules, triangularity, and valuations.

Pieri rules. The operator $e_k \star (\cdot)$ is a sum over k -subsets (Theorem 2.5),

$$e_k \star F = \sum_{|A|=k} \prod_{i \in A, j \notin A} \frac{x_i - tx_j}{x_i - x_j} \prod_{i \in A} x_i \cdot F|_{x_i \mapsto sx_i \ (i \in A)}.$$

From it we derive a closed generating function for $e_k \star (e_{a_1} \cdots e_{a_\ell})$ for all k, ℓ (Theorem 3.2). Since the e_a generate, this determines $e_k \star F$ for every F . The case $\ell = 1$ is a Pieri rule (Corollary 3.3):

$$e_k \star e_r = \sum_{b=0}^k s^b F_{k-b}(t^{r-b}) e_b e_{r+k-b},$$

with explicit polynomials $F_n(w)$, and at $t = 0$ the coefficients form a truncated geometric distribution (Corollary 3.6). In the generating function, the ℓ columns interact only through a pairwise cross kernel, and the proof closes with a single residue identity (Lemma 3.9).

Dominance and valuations. [WIP: Summary of Sections 4 to 9 to be rewritten once those sections are written in full; the statements there are currently those of the extended abstract.]

Organisation. Section 2 sets up Hikita's product and proves the subset formula. Section 3 contains the Pieri package. Section 4 proves dominance support, and Section 5 identifies the $s \rightarrow 0$ edge. Sections 6 and 7 treat the expansion at $s = 1$, Section 8 the box symmetry and the linear coefficient, and Section 9 the second-order leading coefficients.

2. HIKITA'S PRODUCT AND THE SUBSET FORMULA

2.1. Notation. For $m \geq 0$ let $\Lambda_m := \mathbb{Q}(s, t)[x_1, \dots, x_m]^{S_m}$ and let Λ be the ring of symmetric functions over $\mathbb{Q}(s, t)$. We write e_r for the elementary symmetric functions ($e_0 = 1$, $e_r = 0$ for $r < 0$), $e_\lambda = e_{\lambda_1} e_{\lambda_2} \cdots$, and

$$E(z) := \prod_{i=1}^m (1 + x_i z) = \sum_{r \geq 0} e_r z^r, \quad Q(y) := \frac{E(-ty)}{E(-y)} = \prod_{i=1}^m \frac{1 - tx_i y}{1 - x_i y} = \sum_{n \geq 0} q_n y^n,$$

so that the q_n are the one-row Hall–Littlewood functions of [Mac95, III (2.10)]. For a set B of indices, $E(x_B; z) := \prod_{i \in B} (1 + x_i z)$, and $\hat{x}_i$ denotes the variables $x_1, \dots, x_m$ with x_i omitted. We put

$$a_{ij} := \frac{x_i - tx_j}{x_i - x_j}, \quad c_A := \prod_{i \in A, j \notin A} a_{ij}, \quad x_A := \prod_{i \in A} x_i \quad (A \subseteq [m]).$$

Further, $[n] = [n]_t = (1 - t^n)/(1 - t)$, $[n]_t! = [1][2] \cdots [n]$, $(a; t)_n = \prod_{i=0}^{n-1} (1 - at^i)$, $n(\lambda) = \sum_i (i-1)\lambda_i$, and $\supseteq$ is dominance order.

2.2. The level-one representation and Hikita's product. The symmetric group S_m acts on $\mathbb{Q}(s, t)[x_1, \dots, x_m]$ by permuting variables; s_i is the transposition of x_i and x_{i+1} . Define operators on $\mathbb{Q}(s, t)(x_1, \dots, x_m)$ by

$$\begin{aligned} T_i f &:= t s_i f + (t-1) \frac{x_{i+1}}{x_i - x_{i+1}} (s_i f - f) \quad (1 \leq i \leq m-1), \\ \pi f(x_1, \dots, x_m) &:= x_1 f(x_2, \dots, x_m, sx_1), \\ Y_i &:= t^{m-i} T_{i-1} \cdots T_1 \pi T_{m-1}^{-1} \cdots T_i^{-1} \quad (1 \leq i \leq m). \end{aligned}$$

The T_i are Demazure–Lusztig operators; they preserve polynomials, satisfy $(T_i - t)(T_i + 1) = 0$ and the braid relations, and $T_i f = t f$ whenever $s_i f = f$. For $1 \leq k \leq m$ put

$$e_k(Y) := \sum_{b_1 < \dots < b_k} Y_{b_1} Y_{b_2} \cdots Y_{b_k},$$

each product taken in increasing order of indices from left to right. (The Y_i commute, but the proof of Theorem 2.5 does not use this.) Hikita's product $F \star G$ is defined by transporting the product through the map $F(Y) \mapsto F(Y) \bullet 1$; by [Hik25, Lemma 3.1, Cor. 3.9] this map is a linear isomorphism compatible with $m \rightarrow m-1$, so $\star$ is well defined on Λ , and it is commutative and associative [Hik25]. We use $\star$ only through the following consequence of the definitions [Hik25, Def. 3.4, Lemma 3.3]: for symmetric F ,

$$(2.1) \quad e_k \star F = t^{-\binom{k}{2}} e_k(Y) F.$$

2.3. Coxeter preliminaries. We use standard facts about S_m as a Coxeter group with generators $s_1, \dots, s_{m-1}$ [Hum90, §§1.10, 5.12], [BB05, §2.4]. Words act as compositions of operators, the rightmost factor first.

- (H1) For a reduced word $w = s_{i_1} \cdots s_{i_\ell}$ the operator $T_w := T_{i_1} \cdots T_{i_\ell}$ depends only on w , and $T_u T_v = T_{uv}$ whenever $\ell(uv) = \ell(u) + \ell(v)$.
- (H2) For $J \subseteq \{s_1, \dots, s_{m-1}\}$ let W_J be the parabolic subgroup and $W^J = \{w : \ell(ws) > \ell(w) \ \forall s \in J\}$. Every w factors uniquely as $w = w^J w_J$ with $w^J \in W^J$, $w_J \in W_J$, and $\ell(w) = \ell(w^J) + \ell(w_J)$.
- (H3) For $K \subseteq J$, multiplication $W^J \times (W_J)^K \rightarrow W^K$ is a length-additive bijection.
- (H4) If $T_j H = tH$ for all $s_j \in J$, then $T_v H = t^{\ell(v)} H$ for all $v \in W_J$.
- (H5) $\pi T_j = T_{j+1} \pi$ for $1 \leq j \leq m-2$.

(H3) is standard: if $u \in W^J$, $v \in (W_J)^K$ and $s \in K$, then $\ell(uvs) = \ell(u) + \ell(vs) = \ell(uv) + 1$; conversely, for $x \in W^K$ write $x = x^J x_J$, and $x_J s < x_J$ for some $s \in K$ would give $\ell(xs) < \ell(x)$. (H4) is immediate from (H1). For (H5), $\pi s_j f = x_1 f(x_2, \dots, x_{j+2}, x_{j+1}, \dots, s x_1) = s_{j+1} \pi f$ because $j+2 \leq m$, and π turns multiplication by $x_{j+1}/(x_j - x_{j+1})$ into multiplication by $x_{j+2}/(x_{j+1} - x_{j+2})$.

Let $J_n := \{s_i : i \neq n\}$, so $W_{J_n} = S_n \times S_{m-n}$, and the coset wW_{J_n} is determined by $D = w([n])$. Its minimal element w^D is increasing on $[n]$ and on $[n+1, m]$, with $\ell(w^D) = \sum_l (d_l - l)$ for $D = \{d_1 < \dots < d_n\}$. The word

$$w(D) := (s_{d_1-1} \cdots s_1)(s_{d_2-1} \cdots s_2) \cdots (s_{d_n-1} \cdots s_n)$$

sends $l \mapsto d_l$ for $l \leq n$: the blocks with index $l' > l$ fix l , block l sends l to d_l , and the blocks $l' < l$ only move points $\leq d_{l'} < d_l$. It has length $\leq \sum_l (d_l - l)$, so $w(D) = w^D$ and the word is reduced. We write $T_{w(D)}$ for the corresponding operator and

$$\sigma^{(k)} := \sum_{|D|=k} T_{w(D)}.$$

2.4. The parabolic kernel.

Lemma 2.1. *Let $0 \leq n \leq m$, $1 \leq c < d_1 < \dots < d_n \leq m$, and let H satisfy $T_j H = tH$ for all $j \neq n$. Then*

$$(T_c T_{c+1} \cdots T_{m-1})^{-1} T_{w(D)} H = t^{n-(m-c)} T_{w(D-1)} H, \quad D-1 := \{d_1-1, \dots, d_n-1\}.$$

Proof. Let $x := s_c s_{c+1} \cdots s_{m-1}$; it is reduced of length $m-c$, sends $m \mapsto c$ and $i \mapsto i+1$ for $c \leq i \leq m-1$, and fixes $i < c$. Let $y := w(D-1)$; the word is valid since $d_l-1 \geq c+l-1 \geq l$, and $\ell(y) = \ell(w^D) - n$. As $m \notin D-1$, the value m is the largest on the increasing block $[n+1, m]$, so

$y(m) = m$. Since x is increasing on $[1, m-1]$, the inversions of y among positions $< m$ survive in xy ; at position m , $xy(m) = c$ is inverted with exactly those $i < m$ having $y(i) \geq c$, and there are $m - c$ of them. Hence $\ell(xy) = \ell(y) + m - c$. Finally $xy([n]) = x(D-1) = D$ because every $d_l - 1 \geq c$, so $xy = w^D v$ with $v \in W_{J_n}$ and $\ell(v) = \ell(xy) - \ell(w^D) = m - c - n$. By (H1) and (H4), $T_x T_y H = T_{xy} H = T_{w^D} T_v H = t^{m-c-n} T_{w^D} H$. Apply T_x^{-1} . $\square$

Proposition 2.2 (Parabolic kernel). *For symmetric F and $1 \leq b_1 < \dots < b_k \leq m$, $Y_{b_1} Y_{b_2} \dots Y_{b_k} F = t^{\binom{k}{2}} T_{w(\{b_1, \dots, b_k\})} \pi^k F$. Hence*

$$e_k(Y)F = t^{\binom{k}{2}} \sigma^{(k)} \pi^k F.$$

Proof. Note that $\pi^n F = x_1 \dots x_n F(x_{n+1}, \dots, x_m, s x_1, \dots, s x_n)$ is symmetric in $x_1, \dots, x_n$ and in $x_{n+1}, \dots, x_m$, so $T_j \pi^n F = t \pi^n F$ for $j \neq n$. We induct on the number of factors, the empty product being trivial. Let $c < d_1 < \dots < d_n$ and assume $Y_{d_1} \dots Y_{d_n} F = t^{\binom{n}{2}} T_{w(D)} H$ with $H = \pi^n F$. By Lemma 2.1,

$$Y_c t^{\binom{n}{2}} T_{w(D)} H = t^{\binom{n}{2}} t^{m-c} T_{c-1} \dots T_1 \pi (T_c \dots T_{m-1})^{-1} T_{w(D)} H = t^{\binom{n}{2}+n} T_{c-1} \dots T_1 \pi T_{w(D-1)} H.$$

All indices in the word $w(D-1) = \prod_l (s_{d_l-2} \dots s_l)$ lie in $[1, m-2]$, so by (H5), $\pi T_{w(D-1)} = \prod_l (T_{d_l-1} \dots T_{l+1}) \pi$. Now $T_{c-1} \dots T_1 \prod_l (T_{d_l-1} \dots T_{l+1}) = T_{w(\{c\} \cup D)}$, $\pi H = \pi^{n+1} F$, and $\binom{n}{2} + n = \binom{n+1}{2}$. $\square$

2.5. The k -set kernel. Let $\sigma_{[l,m]} := \sum_{a=l}^m T_{a-1} \dots T_l$ be the partial symmetriser on $x_l, \dots, x_m$.

Lemma 2.3. *Let F be symmetric in $x_2, \dots, x_m$, with coefficients in any field containing $\mathbb{Q}(t)$, and let $F^{(i)}$ be F with x_1 and x_i swapped. Then $\sigma_{[1,m]} F = \sum_{i=1}^m F^{(i)} \prod_{j \neq i} a_{ij}$.*

Proof. Induction on m ; $m = 1$ is trivial. Since $s_1 F = F^{(2)}$, a direct computation gives $T_1 F = a_{21} F^{(2)} + (a_{12} - 1) F^{(1)}$. Write $\sigma_{[1,m]} = 1 + \sigma_{[2,m]} T_1$. The function $G := T_1 F$ is symmetric in $x_3, \dots, x_m$, so by induction (over the field with x_1 adjoined) $\sigma_{[2,m]} G = \sum_{i \geq 2} G|_{x_2 \leftrightarrow x_i} \prod_{j \geq 2, j \neq i} a_{ij}$. Under $x_2 \leftrightarrow x_i$, $F^{(2)} \mapsto F^{(i)}$, $F^{(1)}$ is fixed, $a_{21} \mapsto a_{i1}$ and $a_{12} \mapsto a_{1i}$. Hence

$$\sigma_{[1,m]} F = \sum_{i \geq 2} F^{(i)} \prod_{j \neq i} a_{ij} + F^{(1)} \left[1 + \sum_{i \geq 2} (a_{1i} - 1) \prod_{j \geq 2, j \neq i} a_{ij} \right].$$

The function $R(x) := \prod_{j \geq 2} (x - t x_j) / (x - x_j)$ tends to 1 at ∞ and has simple poles at $x = x_i$ with residues $(1-t)x_i \prod_{j \geq 2, j \neq i} a_{ij}$; so $R(x) = 1 + \sum_{i \geq 2} \frac{(1-t)x_i}{x-x_i} \prod_{j \geq 2, j \neq i} a_{ij}$. Evaluating at $x = x_1$ and using $(1-t)x_i / (x_1 - x_i) = a_{1i} - 1$ shows that the bracket equals $R(x_1) = \prod_{j \geq 2} a_{1j}$. $\square$

Proposition 2.4 (k -set kernel). *Let G be symmetric in $x_1, \dots, x_k$ and in $x_{k+1}, \dots, x_m$, and let $G^{(A)}$ denote G with the variables x_A in the first k slots and $x_{[m] \setminus A}$ in the last $m-k$. Then*

$$\sigma^{(k)} G = \sum_{|A|=k} c_A G^{(A)}.$$

Proof. Let $K_l := \{s_{l+1}, \dots, s_{m-1}\}$. The minimal coset representatives of $W_{K_{l-1}}/W_{K_l}$ are $s_{a-1} \dots s_l$ ($l \leq a \leq m$), so applying (H3) along $K_k \subset K_{k-1} \subset \dots \subset K_0$ gives $\sum_{u \in W^{K_k}} T_u = \sigma_{[1,m]} \sigma_{[2,m]} \dots \sigma_{[k,m]}$. Applying (H3) to $K_k \subset J_k$, with $(W_{J_k})^{K_k} = S_k$, gives $\sum_{u \in W^{K_k}} T_u = \sigma^{(k)} \sum_{v \in S_k} T_v$. For G as in the statement, (H4) gives $\sum_{v \in S_k} T_v G = [k]_t! G$, so

$$(2.2) \quad \sigma_{[1,m]} \dots \sigma_{[k,m]} G = [k]_t! \sigma^{(k)} G.$$

On the other hand, if G is merely symmetric in $x_{k+1}, \dots, x_m$, then iterating Lemma 2.3 gives (2.3)

$$\sigma_{[1,m]} \cdots \sigma_{[k,m]} G = \sum_{(a_1, \dots, a_k) \text{ distinct}} G(x_{a_1}, \dots, x_{a_k}; \text{rest}) \omega(a), \quad \omega(a) := \prod_{l=1}^k \prod_{j \notin \{a_1, \dots, a_l\}} a_{a_l j}.$$

Indeed, by induction on k in the variables $x_2, \dots, x_m$, $H := \sigma_{[2,m]} \cdots \sigma_{[k,m]} G$ is the analogous sum over distinct tuples in $[2, m]$; it is symmetric in $x_2, \dots, x_m$, since permuting those variables permutes the terms; and Lemma 2.3 applied to H , followed by $x_1 \leftrightarrow x_{a_1}$, turns tuples in $[2, m]$ into tuples in $[m] \setminus \{a_1\}$.

Now let G be symmetric in both groups. Then $G(x_{a_1}, \dots, x_{a_k}; \text{rest}) = G^{(A)}$ with $A = \{a_1, \dots, a_k\}$, and

$$(2.4) \quad \omega(a) = c_A \prod_{1 \leq l < l' \leq k} a_{a_l a_{l'}}.$$

By the Poincaré identity $\sum_{w \in S_k} w(\prod_{i < j \leq k} a_{ij}) = [k]_t!$ [Mac95, III (1.4)] (which is also (2.2)=(2.3) at $m = k$, $G = 1$), summing over the orderings of A gives $[k]_t! c_A G^{(A)}$. Compare with (2.2). $\square$

Theorem 2.5 (Subset formula). *For every $m \geq 0$, $k \geq 1$ and $F \in \Lambda_m$,*

$$e_k \star F = t^{-\binom{k}{2}} e_k(Y) F = E_k F := \sum_{|A|=k} c_A x_A F|_{x_i \mapsto s x_i \ (i \in A)}.$$

Proof. By Propositions 2.2 and 2.4 with $G = \pi^k F$, since $(\pi^k F)^{(A)} = x_A F|_{x_i \mapsto s x_i \ (i \in A)}$; the first equality is (2.1). For $m < k$ both sides vanish. $\square$

Remark 2.6. For $k = 1$ the subset formula gives back Hikita's rule $e_1 \star e_r = (1-s)[r+1]e_{r+1} + s e_1 e_r$ [Hik25, Thm. 3.12]; see Example 3.4. Proposition 2.4 is the level-one form of the classical expression of the Hecke symmetriser as $\sum_w w \circ \prod_{i < j} a_{ij}$, restricted to minimal coset representatives.

2.6. Two consequences of the kernel. The next two lemmas drive every computation in Section 3. For a function φ of one variable put $S_k^\varphi(x_1, \dots, x_m) := \sum_{|A|=k} c_A \prod_{a \in A} \varphi(x_a)$.

Lemma 2.7 (Peeling one variable). *For $m \geq 1$ and $k \geq 1$, $[k] S_k^\varphi(x) = \sum_{i=1}^m \varphi(x_i) \prod_{j \neq i} a_{ij} S_{k-1}^\varphi(\hat{x}_i)$.*

Proof. By (2.4) and the Poincaré identity, $[k]_t! S_k^\varphi = \sum_a \omega(a) \prod_l \varphi(x_{a_l})$, the sum over distinct k -tuples. Separate $a_1 = i$: $\omega(a) = \prod_{j \neq i} a_{ij} \cdot \omega'(a_2, \dots, a_k)$, where ω' is the weight of (2.3) for the variables $\hat{x}_i$. Summing over $(a_2, \dots, a_k)$ gives $[k-1]_t! S_{k-1}^\varphi(\hat{x}_i)$. $\square$

Lemma 2.8 (Residue form of the HL kernel). *Let $\mathbb{K} \supseteq \mathbb{Q}(t)$ be a field and $H \in \mathbb{K}(v)$ with $H(0) = 0$, such that $H(v)/v$ has only simple poles, at points $p \in \mathbb{K}$, and $H(v)/v = O(1/v)$ at ∞ . Then in $\mathbb{K}(x_1, \dots, x_m)$*

$$(1-t) \sum_{i=1}^m H(x_i) \prod_{j \neq i} a_{ij} = - \sum_p \operatorname{Res}_{v=p} f - \operatorname{Res}_{v=\infty} f, \quad f(v) := \frac{H(v)}{v} \prod_{j=1}^m \frac{v - t x_j}{v - x_j}.$$

Proof. f is regular at $v = 0$, its residue at $v = x_i$ is $(1-t)H(x_i) \prod_{j \neq i} a_{ij}$, and the sum of all residues of a rational function is zero. $\square$

For $H(v) = v^n$, $n \geq 1$, this is $(1-t) \sum_i x_i^n \prod_{j \neq i} a_{ij} = q_n$ [Mac95, III (2.10)]. Note that $\prod_j (v - t x_j)/(v - x_j) = Q(1/v)$ and $Q(-a) = E(ta)/E(a)$.

3. THE PIERI PACKAGE

3.1. The coefficients. For $j \geq 0$ put

$$\alpha_j := \prod_{i=1}^j \frac{s-t^i}{1-t^i} \quad (\alpha_{-1} := 0), \quad c(n, j) := \frac{(s; t)_{n-j}}{(t; t)_{n-j}} (\alpha_j - s t^{n-j} \alpha_{j-1}) \quad (0 \leq j \leq n),$$

and $c(n, j) := 0$ otherwise. Let $F_n(w) := \sum_{j=0}^n c(n, j) w^j$. For instance $F_0 = 1$ and $F_1(w) = (1-s)(1-tw)/(1-t)$.

Lemma 3.1. *Let $G(x) := \sum_{n \geq 0} \frac{(s; t)_n}{(t; t)_n} x^n$, $C_j(x) := \sum_n c(n, j) x^n$, and $D_j := \alpha_j - s \alpha_{j-1}$. Then*

$$(1-x)G(x) = (1-sx)G(tx), \quad C_j(x) = D_j x^j G(tx) \frac{1-st^{-j}x}{1-x},$$

$D_0 = 1$, $D_j = \alpha_{j-1} t^j (s-1)/(1-t^j) \neq 0$ for $j \geq 1$, and $(1-t^j)D_j = (ts-t^j)D_{j-1}$ for $j \geq 1$.

Proof. Write $g_n = (s; t)_n / (t; t)_n$. The first identity says $g_n - g_{n-1} = t^n g_n - s t^{n-1} g_{n-1}$, i.e. $(1-t^n)g_n = (1-s t^{n-1})g_{n-1}$. By definition $C_j(x) = x^j (\alpha_j G(x) - s \alpha_{j-1} G(tx)) = x^j G(tx) (\alpha_j (1-sx) - s \alpha_{j-1} (1-x)) / (1-x)$. The bracket is linear in x . It equals D_j at $x=0$, and at $x=t^j/s$ it equals $\alpha_j (1-t^j) - \alpha_{j-1} (s-t^j) = 0$ (for $j=0$ use $\alpha_{-1}=0$). So it equals $D_j (1-st^{-j}x)$. The formula for D_j follows from $\alpha_j = \alpha_{j-1} (s-t^j)/(1-t^j)$, and the recursion from it and the same relation one step down (for $j=1$ use $D_0=1$). $\square$

3.2. Statements. Fix $\ell \geq 1$ and indeterminates $z_1, \dots, z_\ell$. For integers $i, j \geq 0$ let

$$K_{ij}(z, w) := \prod_{p=0}^{i-1} \frac{t^p z - s w}{t^p z - t^j w} \prod_{r=0}^{j-1} \frac{s z - t^r w}{t^i z - t^r w},$$

and note $K_{ij}(z, w) = K_{ji}(w, z)$. For $I = (i_1, \dots, i_\ell) \in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}^\ell$ with $|I| = S$ put $K_I := \prod_{c < c'} K_{i_c i_{c'}}(z_c, z_{c'})$ and

$$V_I^{(n)} := K_I s^{(\ell-1)(n-S)} \sum_{n_1 + \dots + n_\ell = n} t^{-\sum_{c \neq c'} (n_c - i_c) i_{c'}} \prod_{c=1}^{\ell} t^{-n_c i_c} c(n_c, i_c) z_c^{-n_c},$$

with $V_I^{(n)} := 0$ if some $i_c < 0$. Since $c(n_c, i_c) = 0$ for $n_c < i_c$, $V_I^{(n)} = 0$ unless $S \leq n$.

Theorem 3.2 (ℓ -column rule). *For all $m, k \geq 0$ and $\ell \geq 1$, in $\Lambda_m \otimes \mathbb{Q}(s, t)(z_1, \dots, z_\ell)$,*

$$\Gamma_k := \sum_{a \in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}^\ell} z_1^{a_1} \dots z_\ell^{a_\ell} e_k \star (e_{a_1} \dots e_{a_\ell}) = \sum_{b=0}^k \sum_I (s^\ell t^{-|I|})^b V_I^{(k-b)} e_b \prod_{c=1}^{\ell} E(t^{i_c} z_c).$$

In particular the right-hand side is a polynomial in $z_1, \dots, z_\ell$, and $e_k \star (e_{a_1} \dots e_{a_\ell})$ is its coefficient of z^a . The coefficients do not depend on m , so the identity holds in Λ .

Corollary 3.3 (Pieri rule for $e_k \star e_r$). *For all $k \geq 1$ and $r \geq 0$,*

$$e_k \star e_r = \sum_{b=0}^k s^b F_{k-b}(t^{r-b}) e_b e_{r+k-b}.$$

Equivalently, $\sum_r z^r e_k \star e_r = \sum_{j+b \leq k} s^b t^{-kj} c(k-b, j) e_b z^{b-k} E(t^j z)$.

Proof. Take $\ell = 1$ in Theorem 3.2: $K_I = 1$, and $V_{(j)}^{(n)} = t^{-nj} c(n, j) z^{-n}$, so the right-hand side is the stated generating function. Extract $[z^r]$ using $[z^r] z^{b-k} E(t^j z) = t^{j(r+k-b)} e_{r+k-b}$. $\square$

For $r < k$, distinct b may give the same monomial $e_b e_{r+k-b}$; the identity is between the sums. Since $\star$ is commutative, applying Corollary 3.3 to $e_r \star e_k$ shows that the support of $e_k \star e_r$ is contained in $\{e_b e_{r+k-b} : 0 \leq b \leq \min(k, r)\}$ (see also Theorem 4.1).

Example 3.4 ($k = 1$). $c(1, 0) = \frac{1-s}{1-t}$ and $c(1, 1) = \frac{t(s-1)}{1-t}$, so $F_1(t^r) = (1-s)[r+1]$ and Corollary 3.3 is Hikita's rule $e_1 \star e_r = (1-s)[r+1]e_{r+1} + se_1 e_r$ [Hik25, Thm. 3.12].

Example 3.5 ($k = 2$). One computes $F_2(w) = \frac{(1-s)(1-t^2w)(1-st+(s-t)w)}{(1-t)(1-t^2)}$, so for all $r \geq 0$

$$e_2 \star e_r = \frac{(1-s)(1-t^{r+2})(1-st+(s-t)t^r)}{(1-t)(1-t^2)} e_{r+2} + s(1-s)[r] e_1 e_{r+1} + s^2 e_2 e_r.$$

For $r = 0$ this is $e_2 \star 1 = e_2$.

Corollary 3.6 (The case $t = 0$). For $k \geq 1$, $r \geq 0$, put $\mu = \min(k, r)$ and $M = \max(k, r)$. The coefficients of $e_k \star e_r$ are regular at $t = 0$, and

$$(e_k \star e_r)|_{t=0} = \sum_{b=0}^{\mu-1} (1-s)s^b e_b e_{r+k-b} + s^\mu e_\mu e_M.$$

For $s \in [0, 1]$ the weights $(1-s)s^b$ ($b < \mu$) and s^μ are the law of $\min(G, \mu)$ for a geometric variable G with $P(G = b) = (1-s)s^b$, and the monomials $e_b e_{r+k-b}$ ($b < \mu$), $e_\mu e_M$ are pairwise distinct. So at $t = 0$, $e_k \star e_r$ is a truncated-geometric average of ordinary products.

Corollary 3.7 (Two columns; bounded support). For $\ell = 2$, Theorem 3.2 reads

$$\sum_{a,b \geq 0} z^a w^b e_k \star (e_a e_b) = \sum_{b_0, i, j} s^{2b_0} t^{-b_0(i+j)} V_{ij}^{(k-b_0)} e_{b_0} E(t^i z) E(t^j w),$$

$$V_{ij}^{(n)} = K_{ij}(z, w) \sum_{n_1+n_2=n} s^{n-i-j} t^{-(n_1-i)j-(n_2-j)i-n_1i-n_2j} c(n_1, i) c(n_2, j) z^{-n_1} w^{-n_2}.$$

In general, $e_k \star (e_{a_1} \cdots e_{a_\ell})$ is a linear combination of products of at most $\ell + 1$ elementary symmetric functions.

Proof. The first part is the case $\ell = 2$. For the second, expand both sides of Theorem 3.2 in the field of iterated Laurent series $\mathbb{Q}(s, t)((z_\ell)) \cdots ((z_1))$. The left side is a polynomial, so its expansion is itself. On the right, each term is $R(z) e_b \prod_c E(t^i z_c)$ with R rational and free of x , and its coefficient of z^a is a finite $\mathbb{Q}(s, t)$ -combination of products $e_b \prod_{c=1}^\ell e_{n_c}$. $\square$

3.3. The recursion. By Theorem 2.5, $e_k \star (e_{a_1} \cdots e_{a_\ell}) = \sum_{|A|=k} c_A x_A \prod_c e_{a_c}(x_{A^c}, s x_A)$, and $\sum_a z^a \prod_c e_{a_c}(x_{A^c}, s x_A) = \prod_c \prod_{j \notin A} (1 + x_j z_c) \prod_{i \in A} (1 + s x_i z_c)$. Hence

$$(3.1) \quad \Gamma_k(x) = \prod_c E(z_c) \cdot S_k^\varphi(x), \quad \varphi(u) := u \prod_{c=1}^\ell \frac{1 + s u z_c}{1 + u z_c}.$$

Since $\varphi(x_i) \prod_c E(z_c) = x_i \prod_c (1 + s x_i z_c) \cdot \prod_c E(\hat{x}_i; z_c)$, Lemma 2.7 gives, for $m \geq 1$ and $k \geq 1$,

$$(3.2) \quad [k] \Gamma_k(x) = \sum_{i=1}^m x_i \prod_{c=1}^\ell (1 + s x_i z_c) \prod_{j \neq i} a_{ij} \Gamma_{k-1}(\hat{x}_i),$$

where $\Gamma_{k-1}(\hat{x}_i)$ denotes Γ_{k-1} computed in the $m-1$ variables $\hat{x}_i$. For $m = 0$ we have $\Gamma_0 = 1$ and $\Gamma_k = 0$ for $k \geq 1$.

3.4. The step map. Fix I and put $\gamma_c := t^{i_c} z_c$, $C := s^\ell t^{-|I|} = s^\ell \prod_c z_c / \prod_c \gamma_c$, and

$$\mathcal{F}(v) := \frac{\prod_{c=1}^\ell (v - sz_c)}{v \prod_{c=1}^\ell (v - \gamma_c)} = \frac{C}{v} + \sum_{c=1}^\ell \frac{\kappa_c}{v - \gamma_c}, \quad \kappa_c := \frac{\prod_{c' \neq c} (\gamma_c - sz_{c'})}{\gamma_c \prod_{c' \neq c} (\gamma_c - \gamma_{c'})}.$$

Lemma 3.8 (Step map). *For $b \geq 0$, in $m \geq 1$ variables,*

$$(1-t) \sum_i x_i \prod_c (1 + sx_i z_c) \prod_{j \neq i} a_{ij} e_b(\hat{x}_i) \prod_c E(\hat{x}_i; \gamma_c) = C(1-t^{b+1}) e_{b+1} \prod_c E(\gamma_c) \\ - \sum_{n=0}^b e_n \sum_{c=1}^\ell \kappa_c \gamma_c^{n-b-1} (E(t\gamma_c) - t^n E(\gamma_c)) \prod_{c' \neq c} E(\gamma_{c'}).$$

Proof. Write $u = x_i$. Then $e_b(\hat{x}_i) = [y^b] E(y)/(1+uy)$ and $E(\hat{x}_i; \gamma) = E(\gamma)/(1+\gamma u)$, so the left side is $\prod_c E(\gamma_c) \cdot [y^b] E(y) (1-t) \sum_i H(x_i; y) \prod_{j \neq i} a_{ij}$ with

$$H(v; y) := \frac{v \prod_c (1 + sv z_c)}{(1+yv) \prod_c (1 + \gamma_c v)}$$

(the sum over i is finite and each term is regular at $y = 0$, so $[y^b]$ commutes with it). Apply Lemma 2.8 over $\mathbb{K} = \mathbb{Q}(s, t, z, y)$. The poles of H/v are simple, at $v = -1/a$ for $a \in \{y, \gamma_1, \dots, \gamma_\ell\}$, and $H(v)/v \sim C/(yv)$ at ∞ , which contributes C/y . At $v = -1/a$ the residue of f is $\rho_a E(ta)/E(a)$, where

$$\rho_a = \frac{\prod_c (a - sz_c)}{a \prod_{a' \neq a} (a - a')},$$

as one sees from $\prod_c (1 - sz_c/a) = a^{-\ell} \prod_c (a - sz_c)$, $\prod_{a' \neq a} (1 - a'/a) = a^{-\ell} \prod_{a' \neq a} (a - a')$ and $Q(-a) = E(ta)/E(a)$. Thus $\rho_y = \mathcal{F}(y)$ and $\rho_{\gamma_c} = -\kappa_c/(y - \gamma_c)$, and

$$(1-t) \sum_i H(x_i; y) \prod_{j \neq i} a_{ij} = \frac{C}{y} - \mathcal{F}(y) \frac{E(ty)}{E(y)} + \sum_c \frac{\kappa_c}{y - \gamma_c} \frac{E(t\gamma_c)}{E(\gamma_c)}.$$

Multiply by $E(y) \prod_c E(\gamma_c)$ and write $E(y) = \sum_n e_n y^n$, $E(ty) = \sum_n t^n e_n y^n$. The coefficient of e_n is $[y^{b-n}]$ of the Laurent expansion at $y = 0$ of

$$\left(\frac{C}{y} - t^n \mathcal{F}(y) \right) \prod_c E(\gamma_c) + \sum_c \frac{\kappa_c}{y - \gamma_c} E(t\gamma_c) \prod_{c' \neq c} E(\gamma_{c'}) = \frac{C(1-t^n)}{y} \prod_c E(\gamma_c) + \sum_c \frac{\kappa_c}{y - \gamma_c} (E(t\gamma_c) - t^n E(\gamma_c)) \prod_{c' \neq c} E(\gamma_{c'})$$

by the partial fraction expansion of $\mathcal{F}$. Expanding $1/(y - \gamma) = -\sum_{p \geq 0} y^p \gamma^{-p-1}$ gives the claim: $n = b+1$ picks the pole at 0, $n \leq b$ picks the second sum, and $n > b+1$ contributes nothing. $\square$

3.5. Proof of Theorem 3.2. Write $\mathcal{T}_k$ for the right-hand side of Theorem 3.2, $\mathcal{T}_k = \sum_{b,I} W_{b,I}^{(k)} e_b \prod_c E(t^{i_c} z_c)$ with $W_{b,I}^{(k)} = C_I^b V_I^{(k-b)}$, $C_I := s^\ell t^{-|I|}$; $\epsilon_1, \dots, \epsilon_\ell$ are the unit vectors of $\mathbb{Z}^\ell$.

Reduction to an index identity. We show the step identity

$$(3.3) \quad \sum_i x_i \prod_c (1 + sx_i z_c) \prod_{j \neq i} a_{ij} \mathcal{T}_{k-1}(\hat{x}_i) = [k] \mathcal{T}_k(x) \quad (m \geq 0, k \geq 1)$$

(for $m = 0$ the left side is empty). Given (3.3), the theorem follows by induction on k for all m at once: $\Gamma_0 = \prod_c E(z_c) = \mathcal{T}_0$ because $V_0^{(0)} = 1$; for $m = 0$, (3.3) says $\mathcal{T}_k = 0 = \Gamma_k$; for $m \geq 1$, (3.2), the induction hypothesis in the variables $\hat{x}_i$, and (3.3) give $[k] \Gamma_k = [k] \mathcal{T}_k$.

Apply Lemma 3.8 to each term of $\mathcal{T}_{k-1}(\hat{x}_i)$. The term $e_{b'} \prod_c E(t^{i_c} z_c)$ on the right receives three kinds of contributions: from $(b' - 1, I)$ via the pole at 0; from (b, I) , $b \geq b'$, via $-t^{b'} E(\gamma_c)$; and from $(b, I - \epsilon_c)$, $b \geq b'$, via $E(t\gamma'_c)$ with $\gamma'_c = t^{i_c-1} z_c$. Writing κ'_c for κ_c computed at $I - \epsilon_c$,

$n := k - b'$, $p := b - b'$, and using $C_{I-\epsilon_c} = tC_I$, the coefficient of $e_{b'} \prod_c E(t^{i_c} z_c)$ in $(1-t)$ times the left side of (3.3) is $C_I^{b'}$ times

$$(1-t^{b'})V_I^{(n)} + t^{b'} \sum_{p \geq 0} C_I^p \left[V_I^{(n-1-p)} \sum_c \kappa_c \gamma_c^{-p-1} - t^p \sum_c V_{I-\epsilon_c}^{(n-1-p)} \kappa'_c (t^{i_c-1} z_c)^{-p-1} \right].$$

So (3.3) follows from the index identity

$$(3.4) \quad \sum_{p \geq 0} C_I^p \left[V_I^{(n-1-p)} \sum_c \kappa_c \gamma_c^{-p-1} - t^p \sum_c V_{I-\epsilon_c}^{(n-1-p)} \kappa'_c (t^{i_c-1} z_c)^{-p-1} \right] = (1-t^n) V_I^{(n)} \quad (n \geq 0),$$

because then the coefficient is $C_I^{b'}(1-t^{b'+n})V_I^{(n)} = (1-t^k)W_{b',I}^{(k)}$. (No uniqueness of such expansions is needed: the two sides agree term by term.)

Generating function. Let $\mathcal{V}_I(x) := \sum_{n \geq 0} V_I^{(n)} x^n$. The p -sums in (3.4) are convolutions, and $\sum_{p \geq 0} C^p \gamma^{-p-1} x^{p+1} = x/(\gamma - Cx)$. So (3.4) for all n is equivalent to

$$(3.5) \quad \mathcal{V}_I(x)U(x) - \mathcal{V}_I(tx) = - \sum_c \kappa'_c \frac{x}{t^{i_c-1} z_c - C_I t x} \mathcal{V}_{I-\epsilon_c}(x), \quad U(x) := 1 - \sum_c \frac{\kappa_c x}{\gamma_c - C_I x}.$$

Put $X_c := C_I x / (s z_c)$ and $A_c := t^{i_c}$. Summing over (n_c) in the definition of $V_I^{(n)}$, the exponent of t attached to column c is $-n_c |I| + i_c(|I| - i_c)$, so

$$(3.6) \quad \mathcal{V}_I(x) = K_I s^{-(\ell-1)|I|} t^{|I|^2 - \sum_c i_c^2} \prod_c C_{i_c}(X_c),$$

and passing from I to $I - \epsilon_c$ replaces every $X_{c'}$ by $tX_{c'}$.

Step A: U is a product. By the partial fraction expansion of $\mathcal{F}$, $U(x) = x \mathcal{F}(C_I x)$. Since $C_I x - s z_c = -s z_c(1 - X_c)$, $C_I x - \gamma_c = -\gamma_c(1 - s X_c / A_c)$ and $C_I \prod_c \gamma_c = s^\ell \prod_c z_c$,

$$U(x) = \prod_{c=1}^{\ell} \frac{1 - X_c}{1 - s X_c / A_c}.$$

Step B: normalisation. Divide (3.5) by $\mathcal{N} := K_I s^{-(\ell-1)|I|} t^{|I|^2 - \sum_c i_c^2} \prod_c D_{i_c} X_c^{i_c} G(t^2 X_c)$, which is legitimate since $D_j \neq 0$. By Lemma 3.1 and $G(tX)/G(t^2 X) = (1 - stX)/(1 - tX)$, with $u_c := stX_c$:

- column c of $\mathcal{V}_I U$ contributes $\frac{(1-stX_c)(1-sX_c/A_c)}{(1-tX_c)(1-X_c)} \cdot \frac{1-X_c}{1-sX_c/A_c} = \frac{1-u_c}{1-tX_c}$, and column c of $\mathcal{V}_I(tx)$ contributes $\frac{A_c - u_c}{1-tX_c}$;
- in the c -th term on the right (present only if $i_c \geq 1$), the columns $c' \neq c$ contribute $\frac{A_{c'} - u_{c'}}{1-tX_{c'}}$; column c contributes $\frac{D_{i_c-1}}{D_{i_c}} \frac{A_c}{t} X_c^{-1} \frac{1-st^2 X_c/A_c}{1-tX_c}$ with $D_{i-1}/D_i = (1-A)/(ts-A)$; the prefactors contribute $s^{\ell-1} t^{-2(|I|-i_c)}$; and $\frac{x}{t^{i_c-1} z_c - C_I t x} = \frac{stX_c}{C_I(A_c - st^2 X_c)}$.

It remains to compute $\Phi_c := \kappa'_c K_{I-\epsilon_c} / K_I$. The diagonal factor of κ'_c is $(\gamma'_c - s z_c) / \gamma'_c = (A_c - st) / A_c$. For $c' \neq c$ put $z = z_c$, $w = z_{c'}$, $i = i_c$, $j = i_{c'}$, using $K_{ij}(z, w) = K_{ji}(w, z)$ to place c in the first slot. Then

$$\frac{t^{i-1} z - s w}{t^{i-1} z - t^j w} \cdot \frac{K_{i-1,j}(z, w)}{K_{ij}(z, w)} = \prod_{r=0}^{j-1} \frac{t^i z - t^r w}{t^{i-1} z - t^r w} = t^j \frac{t^i z - w}{t^i z - t^j w},$$

the last product telescoping after writing $t^i z - t^r w = t(t^{i-1} z - t^{r-1} w)$. With $\rho_{cc'} := z_c / z_{c'} = X_{c'} / X_c$ we get

$$\Phi_c = \frac{A_c - st}{A_c} \prod_{c' \neq c} A_{c'} \frac{A_c \rho_{cc'} - 1}{A_c \rho_{cc'} - A_{c'}}.$$

Multiplying everything, $\frac{stX_c}{C_I(A_c-st^2X_c)} \cdot \frac{A_c}{t} X_c^{-1}(1-st^2X_c/A_c) = s/C_I$, then $\frac{s}{C_I} s^{\ell-1} t^{-2(|I|-i_c)} = t^{2i_c-|I|} = A_c/\prod_{c' \neq c} A_{c'}$, and $(A_c-st)/(ts-A_c) = -1$. Hence, after division by $\mathcal{N}$ and multiplication by $\prod_c(1-tX_c)$, (3.5) becomes

$$(3.7) \quad \prod_c(1-u_c) - \prod_c(A_c-u_c) - \sum_c(1-A_c) \prod_{c' \neq c} \frac{A_cX_{c'}-X_c}{A_cX_{c'}-A_{c'}X_c} (A_{c'}-u_{c'}) = 0.$$

(For $i_c = 0$ the c -th term is absent, consistently with the factor $1-A_c=0$.)

Step C: the closing identity. Put $\lambda_c := A_c/u_c$ and $\mu_c := 1/u_c$. Since $X_c \propto u_c$, $\frac{A_cX_{c'}-X_c}{A_cX_{c'}-A_{c'}X_c} = \frac{\lambda_c-\mu_{c'}}{\lambda_c-\lambda_{c'}}$, and $(A_{c'}-u_{c'})/u_{c'} = \lambda_{c'}-1$, $(1-A_c)/u_c = \mu_c-\lambda_c$. Dividing (3.7) by $\prod_c u_c$ turns it into the case of Lemma 3.9 below. As rational functions of x , the $\lambda_c = t^{i_c} z_c/(tC_I x)$ are pairwise distinct and different from 1. Hence (3.5) holds, so (3.4) holds for every n , which proves (3.3) and the theorem. $\square$

Lemma 3.9. *For indeterminates $\lambda_1, \dots, \lambda_\ell, \mu_1, \dots, \mu_\ell$,*

$$\prod_c(\mu_c-1) - \prod_c(\lambda_c-1) = \sum_{c=1}^{\ell} (\mu_c-\lambda_c) \prod_{c' \neq c} (\lambda_{c'}-1) \frac{\lambda_c-\mu_{c'}}{\lambda_c-\lambda_{c'}}.$$

Proof. The rational function $g(w) = \prod_c(w-\mu_c)/((w-1)\prod_c(w-\lambda_c))$ has residue $\frac{\lambda_c-\mu_c}{\lambda_c-1} \prod_{c' \neq c} \frac{\lambda_c-\mu_{c'}}{\lambda_c-\lambda_{c'}}$ at λ_c , residue $\prod_c(1-\mu_c)/\prod_c(1-\lambda_c)$ at 1, and residue -1 at ∞ . The residues sum to zero; multiply by $\prod_c(\lambda_c-1)$. $\square$

Remark 3.10. For $\ell = 1$, Lemma 3.9 is the tautology $(\mu-1) - (\lambda-1) = \mu-\lambda$, and the proof above reduces to a one-index recursion for $c(n, j)$. For $\ell = 2$ it is the polynomial identity that closes the two-column case. The cross kernel K_I is forced by the pairwise splitting of κ'_c in Step B.

3.6. Proof of Corollary 3.6. At $t = 0$, $(t; t)_n = 1$, so every α_j and $c(n, j)$ is regular at $t = 0$; $(s; t)_n|_{t=0} = 1-s$ for $n \geq 1$; hence $F_n(0) = c(n, 0)|_{t=0} = 1-s$ for $n \geq 1$, and $F_0 = 1$.

Case $r \geq k$. Every $b \in [0, k]$ has $r-b \geq 0$, so each term $s^b F_{k-b}(t^{r-b}) = s^b \sum_j c(k-b, j) t^{j(r-b)}$ of Corollary 3.3 is regular at $t = 0$. If $b < r$, the terms with $j \geq 1$ vanish at $t = 0$, leaving $(1-s)s^b$ for $b < k$ and s^k for $b = k$. If $b = r$, then $b = k = r$ and the term is $s^k F_0(1) = s^k$. Summing gives the claim with $\mu = k$.

Case $r < k$. By commutativity of $\star$ [Hik25], $e_k \star e_r = e_r \star e_k$. For $r = 0$ the claim is $e_k \star 1 = e_k$; for $r \geq 1$ apply the first case to (r, k) . $\square$

In the (k, r) -expansion of Corollary 3.3 with $r < k$, the terms with $b > r$ carry negative powers $t^{j(r-b)}$; the argument shows that these cancel once each monomial $e_b e_{r+k-b}$ is collected with its partner $b' = r+k-b$.

Remark 3.11 (Other forms and earlier cases). A second, independent proof of the Pieri rule, in the form $e_k \star e_r = \sum_y s^y C_{k-y, r-y} e_{k+r-y} e_y$ with $C_{a,b} = (-1)^b \frac{[a+b]}{[a]} \pi_a(b)$, is given in Section 8 (Corollary 8.5); it goes through the plethystic linear coefficient of Theorem 8.4 and the Column Lemma. The two forms agree after collecting terms. The kernel form of $e_k(Y)$ on symmetric functions is classical in spirit (Macdonald's D -operators); what is new here is the level-one transfer π^k , the explicit coefficients, and the ℓ -column rule.

4. DOMINANCE SUPPORT

[WIP: The proofs in this section are condensed sketches carried over from the extended abstract; full proofs are to be written from the authors' notes, as in Sections 2 and 3.]

For a partition λ write E_k for the operator of Theorem 2.5 and

$$e_\lambda^\star := e_{\lambda_1} \star \cdots \star e_{\lambda_\ell} = E_{\lambda_1} \cdots E_{\lambda_\ell}(1) = \sum_{\mu} c_{\lambda\mu}(s, t) e_\mu.$$

Theorem 4.1 (Dominance support; the $s = 0$ valuation). $e_\lambda^\star = s^{n(\lambda)} e_\lambda + \sum_{\mu \triangleright \lambda} c_{\lambda\mu} e_\mu$ with $c_{\lambda\mu} \in \mathbb{Q}[s, t]$ and $c_{\lambda\mu}|_{s=1} = 0$. Moreover $c_{\lambda\mu} \neq 0$ for every $\mu \triangleright \lambda$, and the s -adic valuation of $c_{\lambda\mu}$ is exactly $n(\mu)$. At $t = 0$ the s -leading coefficients $[s^{n(\mu)}]c_{\lambda\mu}$ are all 1: in the basis $b_\mu = s^{n(\mu)} e_\mu$, $e_\lambda^\star$ at $s = t = 0$ is the zeta function of dominance order.

Sketch of proof. A termwise degree count on the subset formula: for symmetric P let $\delta_j(P)$ be the maximal total degree in j variables; E_k raises δ_j by at most $\min(k, j)$, and $\delta_j(P) \leq \sum_i \min(\rho_i, j)$ for all j characterises $\text{span}\{e_\nu : \nu \triangleright \rho\}$ [Mac95, I (1.11), (6.6)]. $\square$

5. THE $s \rightarrow 0$ EDGE

[WIP: To contain, with full proofs: the $s \rightarrow 0$ conjugacy (stated in the remark below), the remaining edges of the (s, t) -square, and the reflection $(s, t) \mapsto (1/s, 1/t)$; the $t = 0$ and $t \rightarrow \infty$ edges are cited, not claimed.]

Remark 5.1 (The $s \rightarrow 0$ edge; no novelty claim for the matrix). Since $s = q^{-1}$, the edge $s \rightarrow 0$ is Hikita's $q \rightarrow \infty$, where the unrescaled product degenerates [Hik25, Lemma 6.3]. In the basis b_μ , $e_k \star (\cdot)$ preserves $\bigoplus_{\mu} \mathbb{Q}[s, t] b_\mu$, and modulo s it is conjugate, via $b_\mu \mapsto t^{-n(\mu')} P_{\mu'}(x; t^{-1})$, to multiplication by $t^{-\binom{k}{2}} e_k$. Consequently the leading coefficients $d_{\lambda\mu}(t) := [s^{n(\mu)}] c_{\lambda\mu}$ of Theorem 4.1 are the known $e \rightarrow HL$ transition matrix of [Kir98, §3.2]: writing $e_\lambda = \sum_{\kappa} M(e, P)_{\lambda\kappa} P_{\kappa}(x; t)$,

$$d_{\lambda\mu}(t) = t^{n(\mu') - n(\lambda')} M(e, P)_{\lambda\mu'}(t^{-1}).$$

Their positivity and $d_{\lambda\mu}(1) = \#\{0\text{-}1 \text{ matrices with row sums } \lambda, \text{ column sums } \mu'\}$ are therefore classical [Kir98, §3.2]; what is new is only the identification of this matrix with the s -leading coefficients of $\star$.

6. THE BLOCK VALUATION LAW AT $s = 1$

[WIP: The proofs in this section are condensed sketches carried over from the extended abstract; full proofs are to be written from the authors' notes, as in Sections 2 and 3.]

In Theorem 2.5 the variable s enters only through $F|_{x_i \mapsto sx_i} (i \in A) = s^{\Delta_A} F$, $\Delta_A = \sum_{i \in A} x_i \partial_i$. Taylor expansion at $s = 1$ gives

$$(6.1) \quad E_k = \sum_{p \geq 0} (s-1)^p E_k^{(p)}, \quad E_k^{(p)} = \sum_{|A|=k} c_A x_A \binom{\Delta_A}{p},$$

and $E_k^{(p)}$ is a differential operator of order $\leq p$ on Λ_m , with $E_k^{(0)} = e_k \cdot$ and $E_k^{(p)}(1) = 0$ for $p \geq 1$. We write $\text{lin}_e G := [e_n]G$ for G homogeneous of degree n , $\varphi_m = \prod_{i=1}^m (1 - t^i)$, and use the Hall–Littlewood functions $P_\lambda(x; t)$, $Q_\lambda = b_\lambda P_\lambda$, Q'_λ of [Mac95, Ch. III] with the Hall–Littlewood pairing $\langle p_\lambda, p_\mu \rangle_t = \delta_{\lambda\mu} z_\lambda \prod_i (1 - t^{\lambda_i})^{-1}$. $I = (e_1, e_2, \dots)$ is the augmentation ideal.

Definition 6.1. For $\lambda, \mu \vdash n$, $\kappa(\lambda, \mu)$ is the largest r such that $\lambda = \lambda^1 \sqcup \cdots \sqcup \lambda^r$ and $\mu = \mu^1 \sqcup \cdots \sqcup \mu^r$ as multisets of parts, with every block nonempty and $\mu^i \triangleright \lambda^i$ (so $|\mu^i| = |\lambda^i|$); $\kappa = -\infty$ if $\mu \not\triangleright \lambda$. μ is a *coarsening* of λ if $\kappa(\lambda, \mu) = \ell(\mu)$. v denotes the $(s-1)$ -adic valuation.

Theorem 6.2 (First order is a biderivation). *Let $D_k := E_k^{(1)}$ and $B(f, g) := \partial_s(f \star g)|_{s=1}$. Then D_k is a derivation of Λ_m , and*

$$B(f, g) = \sum_{k,l} M_{kl} \frac{\partial f}{\partial e_k} \frac{\partial g}{\partial e_l}, \quad M_{kl} := D_k(e_l) = B(e_k, e_l) = M_{lk}.$$

So B is a symmetric biderivation, the carré du champ of $L = \frac{1}{2} \sum M_{kl} \partial^2 / \partial e_k \partial e_l$.

Sketch of proof. $(\Delta_1^A) = \Delta_A$ is a derivation and left multiplication by $c_A x_A$ preserves this. Write $f = \sum_\rho a_\rho(s) e_\rho^*$, differentiate $f \star g = \sum_\rho a_\rho(s) E_\rho g$ at $s = 1$, and use $D_k(1) = 0$. Symmetry of M is commutativity of $\star$ [Hik25]. $\square$

Proposition 6.3 (The matrix M). *For $k \geq r \geq 0$, with $L(a, b) := \frac{(1 - t^{a+b})(t^{ab} - 1)}{(1 - t^a)(1 - t^b)}$,*

$$M_{kr} = B(e_k, e_r) = r e_k e_r + \sum_{j=1}^r L(k - r + j, j) e_{k+j} e_{r-j}.$$

Consequently $[(s-1)^1] e_\lambda^ = \sum_{i < j} M_{\lambda_i \lambda_j} e_{\lambda \setminus \{\lambda_i, \lambda_j\}}$.*

Sketch of proof. Differentiate Corollary 8.5 (whose proof does not use Proposition 6.3) at $s = 1$. Since $\pi_a(b)|_{s=1} = \delta_{b0}$, only $y = r$ survives at $s = 1$, and its derivative is $r e_k e_r$. For $y = r - j$, $j \geq 1$, put $a = k - r + j$. Then $\partial_s \pi_a(j)|_{s=1} = [u^j] \sum_{m < a} \frac{ut^m}{1+ut^m} = (-1)^{j-1} [a]_{t^j}$, so $\partial_s C_{a,j}|_{s=1} = -\frac{[a+j]}{[a]} [a]_{t^j} = L(a, j)$. The second statement follows from Theorem 6.2, since $D_k(1) = 0$. $\square$

Theorem 6.4 (Block valuation law). *For all $\lambda, \mu \vdash n$ and all t , $v(c_{\lambda\mu}) \geq \ell(\lambda) - \kappa(\lambda, \mu)$. For $\mu \geq \lambda$, $\mu \neq \lambda$, equality holds over $\mathbb{Q}(t)$ and at $t = 0$:*

$$v(c_{\lambda\mu}) = \ell(\lambda) - \kappa(\lambda, \mu).$$

At $t = 0$ the leading coefficient is $(-1)^{\ell-\kappa} N(\lambda, \mu)$ with $N(\lambda, \mu) \geq 1$ a count of minimal raising-operator configurations.

Sketch of proof. Lower bound (subset formula only): by polarization, an order- p operator glues at most p existing “blocks” to the new part, so the $(s-1)^m$ coefficient is a sum of products over $\geq \ell - m$ blocks, each of type λ_C by the degree count of Theorem 4.1. *Equality:* at $t = 0$, $\omega e_\lambda^* = \tilde{H}_\lambda(x; s) = s^{n(\lambda)} Q'_\lambda(x; s^{-1})$, and Macdonald’s raising operators $Q'_\lambda(x; u) = \prod_{i < j} \frac{1 - R_{ij}}{1 - u R_{ij}} h_\lambda$ [Mac95, III (2.15')] with §5 Ex. 7(a)] give R_{ij}^k the coefficient $(u-1)u^{k-1} = -(s-1)s^{-k}$ at $u = s^{-1}$. So every transfer edge costs exactly one $(s-1)$ with sign -1 , so nothing cancels; the minimum edge count is $\ell - \kappa$ (components $\leq \kappa$; a path tree on each indecomposable block). Specialise $t = 0 \rightarrow$ generic. $\square$

Remark 6.5 (Input at $t = 0$). The $t = 0$ edge $e_{\mu'}^*|_{t=0} = s^{n(\mu)} P_{\mu'}(x; 1/s, 0) = \omega \tilde{H}_\mu(x; s)$ is **not ours**: it is assembled from [DFK18] eq. (5.15) (with $M_{k,1} = E_k|_{t=0}$), Cor. 5.8 in its level-one form (5.25), Cor. 5.18 (eq. (5.27)) (numbering of arXiv:1505.01657v2), and [Mac95, VI (5.1), (4.14)(iv)]. In particular Theorem 6.4 does not depend on Cherednik’s nonsymmetric theory.

Remark 6.6 (Novelty). We have not found the block law stated anywhere. Its $t = 0$ case is classical in substance: the raising-operator formula follows from [DLT94, eq. (11)] and Jacobi–Trudi, after which the valuation count above is a short exercise. What is new is the lower bound for all t (from the subset formula alone), the exactness over $\mathbb{Q}(t)$, and the merge weights below.

Theorem 6.7 (Coarsenings: merge-history expansion). *Let $\mu \neq \lambda$ be a coarsening of λ and $m = \ell(\lambda) - \ell(\mu)$. Then $v(c_{\lambda\mu}) = m$, and $\text{Lead}_{\lambda\mu}(t) := [(s-1)^m]c_{\lambda\mu}$ equals*

$$\text{Lead}_{\lambda\mu}(t) = \sum_{\text{tight histories } H \text{ ending at } \mu} \prod_{\text{merges in } H} W_k(J), \quad \text{Lead}_{\lambda\mu}(0) = (-1)^m \#\{H\} \neq 0,$$

where a (tight) history processes $\lambda_\ell, \dots, \lambda_1$, each part k either opening a block of size k or merging $p \geq 1$ existing blocks of sizes $J = (j_1, \dots, j_p)$ into one block of size $k + |J|$ via the order- p piece $E_k^{(p)}$, it ends at μ if the final block sizes are μ , and $W_k(J) := \text{lin}_e[\dots[E_k^{(p)}, e_{j_1}], \dots, e_{j_p}](1)$.

Sketch of proof. Pass to $\text{gr}_I \Lambda$: non-tight terms land in $I^{\ell-m+1}$; tight steps are multilinear derivations, so only linear parts $g_i \equiv \gamma_i e_{n_i} \bmod I^2$ matter. At $t = 0$, a roots-of-unity evaluation, Weyl orthogonality and Murnaghan–Nakayama give $W_k(J)|_{t=0} = (-1)^p$. $\square$

Theorem 6.8 (Merge weights). *With $n = k + |J|$ and $p = |J|$,*

$$W_k(J) = (-1)^p \frac{[n]_t}{[k]_t} \prod_{j \in J} [k]_{t^{j_j}}.$$

Consequently $(-1)^m \text{Lead}_{\lambda\mu}(t) > 0$ for coarsenings and every real $t > 0$.

Sketch of proof. $W_k(J) = (-1)^{d-p} \text{lin}_e T_k(p_J)$, $d = |J|$, with T_k as in Lemma 6.9. The parabolic factorisation $T_k P_\rho = P_{\rho+1^k}$ [Mac95, III (2.2)] and $\text{lin}_e P_\lambda = (-1)^{n-k} \frac{[n]_t}{[k]_t} P_{\lambda-1^k}(1, t, \dots, t^{k-1})$ (from [Mac95, III.7 Ex. 2, III.2 Ex. 1]) give the “discrete HL measure = principal specialisation” identity $\text{lin}_e T_k f = (-1)^d \frac{[n]_t}{[k]_t} f(1, t, \dots, t^{k-1})$ (Lemma 6.9); apply it to $f = p_J$. $\square$

Lemma 6.9. *Let $T_k f := \sum_{|A|=k} c_A x_A f(x_A)$ for $f \in \Lambda_k$. For f homogeneous of degree d and $n = k + d$:*

$$\text{lin}_e T_k(f) = (-1)^d \frac{[n]_t}{[k]_t} f(1, t, \dots, t^{k-1}).$$

Remark 6.10 (Novelty). Lemma 6.9 is a short corollary of [Mac95, III.7 Ex. 2, III (2.2)] and is probably known.

7. LEADING COEFFICIENTS: GRAPH CUMULANTS AND BLOCKS

[WIP: The proofs in this section are condensed sketches carried over from the extended abstract; full proofs are to be written from the authors’ notes, as in Sections 2 and 3.]

Theorem 7.1 (Full-merge lead). *For $\lambda \vdash n$ with $\ell = \ell(\lambda) \geq 2$,*

$$\text{Lead}_{\lambda, (n)}(t) = \frac{1 - t^n}{\prod_i (1 - t^{\lambda_i})} K_\lambda(t), \quad K_\lambda(t) := \sum_{H \text{ connected on } [\ell]} \prod_{ij \in H} (t^{\lambda_i \lambda_j} - 1).$$

K_λ is the connected part (joint cumulant) of $t^{e_2(\lambda)} = \prod_{i < j} (1 + (t^{\lambda_i \lambda_j} - 1))$.

Sketch of proof. (1) Tight histories ending in one block are increasing trees on $[\ell]$ (parent = the merging part). (2) With N_v the λ -mass of the subtree at v , Theorem 6.8 telescopes along the tree to $\prod \frac{1-t^n}{(1-t^{\lambda_i})} \prod_{v \rightarrow c} (t^{\lambda_v N_c} - 1)$. (3) Tree-graph identity: $\sum_{\text{incr. trees}} \prod_{v \rightarrow c} (\prod_{j \in T_c} x_{vj} - 1) = \sum_{\text{conn. } H} \prod_{e \in H} (x_e - 1)$ for generic x , by the minimum-vertex/component decomposition; specialise $x_{ij} = t^{\lambda_i \lambda_j}$. $\square$

Corollary 7.2. (a) $\lambda = 1^n$: $\text{Lead} = (-1)^{n-1} [n]_t I_n(t)$ with I_n the tree inversion enumerator [MR68]. (b) $t = 0$: $\text{Lead} = (-1)^{\ell-1} (\ell-1)!$. (c) $t \rightarrow 1$: $\text{Lead} \rightarrow (-1)^{\ell-1} n^{\ell-1}$ (weighted Cayley). (d) $\text{sgn Lead} = (-1)^{\ell-1}$ for all $t > 0$.

Proof. At $t = 0$ every edge weight is -1 and $\sum_{H \text{ conn.}} (-1)^{|H|} = (-1)^{\ell-1}(\ell-1)!$. As $t \rightarrow 1$, with $\varepsilon = t - 1$, only spanning trees contribute to the $\varepsilon^{\ell-1}$ term of K_λ , and $\sum_T \prod_{ij \in T} \lambda_i \lambda_j = (\prod_i \lambda_i) n^{\ell-2}$ (weighted Cayley); the prefactor is $(-n\varepsilon)/((- \varepsilon)^\ell \prod \lambda_i) \cdot (1 + O(\varepsilon))$. (d) is the case $\mu = (n)$, $m = \ell - 1$, of the sign statement in Theorem 6.8: each merge contributes $(-1)^p$ times a positive quantity, $\sum p = m$ along every history, and histories exist. $\square$

Remark 7.3 (Prior art — graph half). The tree, connected-graph and cumulant forms of K_λ are a special case of Dołęga [Do19, Prop. 2.1 and (11), Lemma 2.3] ($K_\lambda = (t-1)^{\ell-1}T(1, t)$ for the Tutte polynomial of the multigraph with $\lambda_i \lambda_j$ edges between i and j), cf. also [GS96; MR68]; step (3) is a Penrose-type tree-graph identity [Pen67]. Ours: the identification of the $\star$ -lead with prefactor $\cdot K_\lambda$ (Theorems 6.7, 6.8 and 7.1) and Theorems 7.4 and 7.5. Haglund–Tewari’s single-row cumulant [HT26, Def. 7.1, Thm. 7.3] (their q is our t) is the same graph half: since $\langle \tilde{H}_{(m)}, e_m \rangle = q^{\binom{m}{2}}$, their cumulant $\kappa(\lambda)$ (we write C_λ) satisfies $\langle C_\lambda, e_n \rangle = t^{n(\lambda')}(t-1)^{1-\ell} K_\lambda(t)$. *Separator.* Full-merge leads $L(\lambda)$ of any such theory are only defined up to the gauge $L(\lambda) \mapsto L(\lambda) a^{\ell(\lambda)} g(|\lambda|) \prod_i f(\lambda_i)$ (rescaling generators, degree-wise normalisation, rescaling the expansion parameter). The first gauge invariant appears at $n = 4$: $J := L(1^4)L(2, 2)/L(2, 1, 1)^2$ (the exponents of $a, g(4), f(1)$ and $f(2)$ all cancel). For $\star$, Theorem 7.1 gives $J = \frac{(t^2+1)(t^3+3t^2+6t+6)}{(t+1)(t^2+t+2)^2}$, and Haglund–Tewari’s $\langle C_\lambda, e_n \rangle$ gives the same value. Dołęga’s $\oplus$ -cumulant of columns (lowest $(q-1)$ -coefficient of $[g_n]\tilde{H}_{\lambda'}$, $g_k = \tilde{H}_{1^k}$) gives, by computation, $J \equiv 3/2 = J_\star(0)$, whereas $J_\star(1) = 1$, the Cayley value. So up to gauge Dołęga’s $\oplus$ is t -independent and agrees with $\star$ only at $t = 0$, where the leads are partition-lattice Möbius values (Corollary 7.2(b)), while Haglund–Tewari’s is the same graph object without $\star$.

Theorem 7.4 (Coarsening leads factor). *For μ a coarsening of λ ,*

$$\text{Lead}_{\lambda\mu} = \sum_{\pi} \prod_{B \in \pi} \text{Lead}_{\lambda_B, (|\lambda_B|)},$$

summed over set partitions π of the positions $[\ell]$ whose sorted block sums equal μ (singletons contribute 1). There is no interleaving factor.

Sketch of proof. Increasing forests = set partition $\times$ increasing tree per block, and the telescoped weight is local to each tree. $\square$

Theorem 7.5 (Block multiplicativity). *Let $\kappa = \kappa(\lambda, \mu) \geq 1$, $\ell = \ell(\lambda)$, $m = \ell - \kappa$. Then*

$$[(s-1)^m] c_{\lambda\mu} = \sum_{\pi} \sum_{(\nu^C)_{C \in \pi}} \prod_{C \in \pi} [(s-1)^{|C|-1}] c_{\lambda_C, \nu^C},$$

where π runs over set partitions of $[\ell]$ into exactly κ blocks and (ν^C) over tuples with $\bigsqcup_C \nu^C = \mu$ and $\nu^C \supseteq \lambda_C$; every factor then has $\kappa(\lambda_C, \nu^C) = 1$. With Theorem 6.4 this is $\text{Lead}_{\lambda\mu}$.

Sketch of proof. Expand by polarization into histories; non-tight histories produce $> \kappa$ compatible blocks and vanish by maximality of κ ; tight histories factor block by block and interleave uniquely. Uses commutativity of $\star$ [Hik25] only to pass from compositions to partitions. $\square$

Remark 7.6. Theorem 7.4 is the case where each ν^C is a single part. The factorisation has the shape of a Mayer (cluster) expansion, i.e. moment–cumulant inversion of the graph identity in Theorem 7.1; the $\star$ -specific content is that the connected leads are those of Theorem 7.1, with no interleaving correction.

8. BOX COMPLEMENT AND THE LINEAR COEFFICIENT

[WIP: The proofs in this section are condensed sketches carried over from the extended abstract; full proofs are to be written from the authors’ notes, as in Sections 2 and 3.]

Theorem 8.1 (Box Complement). *Let λ, μ have at most ℓ parts (padded with zeros) and all parts $\leq N$; put $N^\ell - \lambda := (N - \lambda_\ell, \dots, N - \lambda_1)$. Then*

$$c_{N^\ell - \lambda, N^\ell - \mu}(s, t) = s^{N \binom{\ell}{2} - (\ell-1)|\lambda|} c_{\lambda\mu}(s, t).$$

Sketch of proof. Stability of the subset formula for every N (also $N < \text{degree}$), and an inversion lemma in N variables: for $F = e_N^m G(1/x)$ with G of degree g ,

$$E_{N-k} F = s^{m(N-k)-g} e_N^{m+1}(E_k G)(1/x)$$

(substitute $y = 1/x$, $B = A^c$). Iterate, and compare coefficients using the identity $e_{N-r}(x) = e_N(x) e_r(1/x)$ and Theorem 4.1 (support has $\leq \ell$ parts). $\square$

Corollary 8.2 (Column Lemma; lead invariance). $c_{\lambda+1^\ell, \mu+1^\ell} = s^{\binom{\ell}{2}} c_{\lambda\mu}$. Hence v and Lead are invariant under $(\lambda, \mu) \mapsto (\lambda + 1^\ell, \mu + 1^\ell)$ and $(\lambda, \mu) \mapsto (N^\ell - \lambda, N^\ell - \mu)$; e.g. $(2, 2, 2) \rightarrow (3, 3)$ and $(2, 2, 2) \rightarrow (4, 1, 1)$ have the lead $[3]_t(t+2)$ of $(1, 1, 1) \rightarrow (3)$.

Remark 8.3 (Prior art). The inversion lemma follows in a few lines from [DFK19, Rem. 3.3] ($S\Gamma_I S = \Gamma_I^{-1}$ under $x \mapsto x^{-1}$) plus subset complement; stability is [Hik25, Prop. 3.8, Cor. 3.10]. We have not found Theorem 8.1 or Corollary 8.2 for $\star$ in the literature.

Theorem 8.4 (Plethystic linear coefficient). *For G homogeneous of degree d : $\text{lin}_e(e_k \star G) = (-1)^d \frac{[k+d]_t}{[k]_t} G[(s-1)[k]_t]$, where $G \mapsto G[(s-1)[k]_t]$ is the ring map $p_r \mapsto (s^r - 1)[k]_{tr}$.*

Corollary 8.5 (Pieri rule, all s). $e_k \star e_r = \sum_{y=0}^{\min(k,r)} s^y C_{k-y, r-y} e_{k+r-y} e_y$ with $C_{a,0} = C_{0,b} = 1$, $C_{a,b} = (-1)^b \frac{[a+b]_t}{[a]_t} \pi_a(b)$, $\pi_a(j) = [u^j] \prod_{m=0}^{a-1} \frac{1+sut^m}{1+ut^m}$.

Sketch of proof. Support by Theorem 4.1; strip y columns by Corollary 8.2 (valid for compositions) to reduce to $\text{lin}_e E_{k-y}(e_{r-y})$; evaluate by Theorem 8.4, which itself is Lemma 6.9 applied to the generating function $E_k(\prod_i E(u_i)) = \prod_i E(u_i) T_k(\prod_i \prod_{a \in A} \frac{1+su_i x_a}{1+u_i x_a})$. $\square$

Remark 8.6. Corollary 8.5 was first obtained by a different route, a k -fold kernel computation; Hikita's [Hik25, Thm. 3.12] is the case $k = 1$. Explicit rules for $e_k \star e_\lambda$ with λ of two or ℓ columns will appear in the long version.

9. SECOND ORDER: EVERY VALUATION-2 LEAD

[WIP: The proofs in this section are condensed sketches carried over from the extended abstract; full proofs are to be written from the authors' notes, as in Sections 2 and 3.]

By Theorem 7.5, valuation-2 leads reduce to connected leads with $\ell(\lambda) = 3$, $\kappa = 1$; by Corollary 8.2 to two-part μ . With T_a as in Lemma 6.9, put

$$\Gamma_a(e_b, e_c) := E_a^{(2)}(e_b e_c) - e_b E_a^{(2)}(e_c) - e_c E_a^{(2)}(e_b) = \sum_{1 \leq r \leq b, 1 \leq q \leq c} (-1)^{r+q} e_{b-r} e_{c-q} T_a(p_r p_q).$$

Proposition 9.1. *If (a, b, c) is any ordering of λ and $\kappa(\lambda, \mu) = 1$, then $[(s-1)^2] c_{\lambda\mu} = [e_\mu](\Gamma_a(e_b, e_c) + D_a D_b(e_c))$.*

Theorem 9.2 (Constant-term adjoint formula). *For $g \in \Lambda_a$, $F \in \Lambda$: $\varphi_a(t) \langle T_a g, F \rangle_t = \text{CT}[Z g(z) F(z_1^{-1}, \dots, z_a^{-1})]$ where $Z = z_1 \cdots z_a$ and $\Omega(z) = \prod_{1 \leq i < j \leq a} \frac{z_j - z_i}{z_j - t z_i}$, expanded in z_i/z_j ($i < j$).*

Sketch of proof. $T_a g$ restricted to a variables is Zg and lies in $\text{span}\{P_\mu : \ell(\mu) = a\}$. Evaluate $\langle G, q_\alpha \rangle_t = [y^\alpha] G$ via Cauchy [Mac95, III (4.2), (4.4), (4.8)–(4.9)], write $\langle G, Q_\lambda \rangle_t$ as a constant term by the raising-operator formula [Mac95, III (2.15')], and symmetrise $\Omega = \Delta\theta$ with $\sum_w w(\theta) = v_a(t)$ [Mac95, III (1.4)]; $Q_\lambda(z^{-1})$ is evaluated by [Mac95, III (2.1), (2.11)–(2.12)]. This is Jing's vertex-operator calculus [Jin91] with the vertex operators hidden. $\square$

Theorem 9.3 (Two-point formula). *Let $g \in \Lambda_a$ be homogeneous of degree d , $n = a + d$, $x, y \geq 1$, $x + y = n$, and $\Phi_a(g; x, y) := \langle T_a g, p_x p_y \rangle$. For $1 \leq A \leq a - 1$ put $B = a - A$ and $G_A(w) = \sum_k G_{A,k} w^k := g(1, t, \dots, t^{A-1}, w, wt, \dots, wt^{B-1})$. Then*

$$\begin{aligned} \Phi_a(g; x, y) = (-1)^a (1 - t^x)(1 - t^y) & \left\{ \sum_{A=1}^{a-1} t^{-AB} \left[\frac{G_{A,y-B}}{(1 - t^A)(1 - t^B)} \right. \right. \\ & + \frac{1}{1 - t^a} \sum_{m \geq 1} (t^{-Am} - t^{Bm}) G_{A,y-B-m} \Big] \\ & \left. \left. - \frac{g(1, t, \dots, t^{a-1})}{1 - t^a} \sum_{j=0}^{a-1} t^{-jy} \right\}. \end{aligned}$$

Sketch of proof. Insert $S(u) = \sum_i 1/(uz_i - 1)$ into Theorem 9.2 and take iterated residues: every variable lands on a t -string $1/u, t/u, \dots$ or $1/v, t/v, \dots$. A string of length A with base q has weight $(-1)^{A-1} \varphi_{A-1} q^A$, and two strings interact through the shuffle identity

$$\text{Sh}_{A,B}(w) = \left[\begin{matrix} A+B \\ A \end{matrix} \right]_t t^{-AB} \frac{(1-w)(1-t^{B-A}w)}{(1-t^A w)(1-t^B w)}, \quad w = u/v,$$

proved by a last-letter recursion. Take Taylor coefficients at $w = 0$. $\square$

Remark 9.4 (Relation to Green polynomials). Write $p_\mu = \sum_\lambda X_\mu^\lambda(t) P_\lambda(x; t)$. For $g = P_\rho$ and $\lambda = \rho + 1^a$ one has $\Phi_a(P_\rho; x, y) = (1 - t^x)(1 - t^y) X_{(x,y)}^\lambda(t) / b_\lambda(t)$, so Theorem 9.3 evaluates Green polynomials at two-part classes; the two t -strings are the Frobenius orbits of a maximal torus of type (x, y) [Gre55]. Theorem 9.2 is Jing's constant-term expression for the matrix element $\langle Q_\lambda, p_\mu \rangle$ [Jin91], cf. [JL21, (2.17), (2.20)]. Jing and Liu [JL21, Thm. 2.7] expand the same matrix element as a nested sum valid for all μ , extracting one variable at a time; at two-part μ that sum does not close up, since its inner sums run over classes of arbitrary length. Their closed forms [JL21, Thm. 2.10, (2.37)–(2.40)] restrict the Hall–Littlewood index λ , not the class μ ; their Murnaghan–Nakayama rule [JL21, Thm. 3.2] generalises a formula of Morris [Mor77]¹, its case $\ell(\lambda) = 2$. We evaluate by residues instead, and at $\ell(\mu) = 2$ the poles organise into two t -strings. The formula is explicit, with no sum over classes, and linear in the two-string specialisation G_A of g ; for general ρ , G_A is itself a finite (branching) sum, so Theorem 9.3 is not a product formula.

Example 9.5 (Two rows). For $a = 2$, only $A = B = 1$ occurs, and $G_1(w) = P_\rho(1, w; t) = w^{\rho_2} \frac{(1-tw) - w^r(w-t)}{1-w}$ with $r = \rho_1 - \rho_2 \geq 1$ ($G_1 = w^{\rho_2}$ if $r = 0$). Substituting into Theorem 9.3 gives, for $\lambda = (\lambda_1, \lambda_2)$, $y \leq x$, and $m_{xy} = 2$ if $x = y$, 1 otherwise,

$$X_{(x,y)}^{(\lambda_1, \lambda_2)}(t) = \begin{cases} (t-1) t^{\lambda_2-1-y} (1+t^y), & y < \lambda_2, \\ m_{xy} - (1-t) t^{\lambda_2-1}, & y = \lambda_2, \\ (t-1) t^{\lambda_2-1}, & y > \lambda_2, \end{cases}$$

in agreement with a Kostka–Foulkes computation for $|\lambda| \leq 10$. This is not new: for $\lambda = (n-k, k)$ and every class ρ , Jing and Liu [JL21, §2, display after (2.32)] give $X_\rho^\lambda = \pi_k + (t-1) \sum_{j < k} t^{k-1-j} \pi_j$, with π_j the number of j -subsets fixed by ρ (their $D^{(j)}(\rho)$). A short proof: $X_\rho^\lambda = \sum_\nu \chi_\rho^\nu K_{\nu\lambda}(t)$ [Mac95, III (7.6')], where $K_{(n-j,j),\lambda} = t^{k-j}$ (one tableau, and K is monic of degree $n(\lambda) - n(\nu)$ [Mac95, III (6.5)]) and $\chi_\rho^{(n-j,j)} = \pi_j - \pi_{j-1}$ by Young's rule. On the diagonal class $(x, y) = \lambda$ it gives $t^{\lambda_2} - t^{\lambda_2-1} + m_{xy}$, which for $\lambda_1 > \lambda_2$ with $\lambda_2 \geq 3$ odd equals -1 at

¹We have not seen [Mor77] first-hand; its scope is as described in [JL21, p. 12, before Thm. 3.2].

$t = -1$ and 1 at $t = 0$. A root in $(-1, 0)$ rules out a product of cyclotomic factors and powers of t , and Green polynomials at two-part classes admit no product formula even for two rows; for products of the form $t^c \prod_i (1 - t^{d_i})$ this was observed independently in [Cli26, Thm. D].

Theorem 9.6 (Closed $\ell = 3$, $\kappa = 1$ leads). *Let $\lambda = (a, b, c)$ be any ordering of a length-3 partition, $\mu = (x, y)$ with $\kappa(\lambda, \mu) = 1$, $n = x + y$, m_{xy} as in Example 9.5. Put*

$$\Xi_a(r, q) := \text{lin}_e T_a(p_r p_q) = (-1)^{r+q} \frac{[a+r+q]}{[a]} [a]_{t^r} [a]_{t^q}$$

and $U_a(b, c; x, y) := ((-1)^n \Phi_a(p_b p_c; x, y) - \Xi_a(b, c)) / m_{xy}$. Then

$$\begin{aligned} [(s-1)^2] c_{\lambda\mu} = & (-1)^{b+c} U_a(b, c; x, y) + \sum_{\substack{1 \leq r < b \\ \{b-r, a+r+c\} = \{x, y\}}} (-1)^{r+c} \Xi_a(r, c) \\ & + \sum_{\substack{1 \leq q < c \\ \{c-q, a+b+q\} = \{x, y\}}} (-1)^{b+q} \Xi_a(b, q) + [e_x e_y] D_a(M_{bc}), \end{aligned}$$

with D_a the derivation $D_a(e_j) = M_{aj}$ of Proposition 6.3.

Sketch of proof. Proposition 9.1; in the expansion of Γ_a only terms with $r = b$ or $q = c$ survive $[e_x e_y]$; single- e parts come from Lemma 6.9, and $\langle G, p_x p_y \rangle = (-1)^n (m_{xy} [e_x e_y] G + \text{lin}_e G)$ converts Theorem 9.3 into U_a . $\square$

Corollary 9.7. *Every lead at valuation 2 ($\kappa = \ell - 2$, any ℓ) has a closed formula: by Theorem 7.5 it is a sum of products of pair leads (Proposition 6.3) and $\ell = 3$, $\kappa = 1$ leads (Theorem 7.1, Corollary 8.2, Theorem 9.6).*

Example 9.8. $(3, 3, 3) \rightarrow (7, 2)$: $\text{Lead} = 2t^{13} + 3t^{12} + 3t^{11} + 6t^{10} + 6t^9 + 6t^8 + 9t^7 + 6t^6 + 3t^5 + 9t^4 + 6t^3 + 3t + 4$ (agrees with direct computation). Leads are *not* positive in general: $(4, 4, 2) \rightarrow (7, 3)$ has $\text{Lead} = (t+1)(t^2+1)(2t^8+t^7+t^6+3t^4+t^3+t^2-t+2)$.

Computer checks. All statements in this section were checked against an independent implementation of Hikita's subset formula: Theorem 9.6 on 16 pairs with $n \leq 12$ (both examples among them) and on 27 pairs in all 3 orderings with $n \leq 10$; Theorem 9.3 in 229 cases ($a \leq 5$); and the Green-polynomial dictionary symbolically for $|\lambda| \leq 8$ and numerically for $|\lambda| \leq 9$.

10. OPEN PROBLEMS

- (1) **Valuation ≥ 3 .** Connected leads with $\ell \geq 4$, $\kappa = 1$. Hierarchy: $v = 1 \leftrightarrow p_n \leftrightarrow$ one t -string (Lemma 6.9); $v = 2 \leftrightarrow p_x p_y \leftrightarrow$ two strings (Theorem 9.3). Does the three-string shuffle sum factor pairwise?
- (2) **Zero set at generic t .** At $t = -2$ seven pairs with $n = 6$ have $v > \ell - \kappa$; for coarsenings this is cancellation between histories, e.g. $\text{Lead}_{(1,1,1),(3)} = [3]_t(2+t)$. Describe the zero set of $[(s-1)^{\ell-\kappa}] c_{\lambda\mu}$ in t .
- (3) **Counting.** A formula for $N(\lambda, \mu)$ in Theorem 6.4; for $\ell(\lambda) = 3$ and $\mu = (n-1, 1)$ with $\kappa = 1$ we observe $\text{Lead}_{\lambda\mu}(1) = 2n^2 - 6n + 3$, independent of λ ($n \leq 10$; computed only).
- (4) **Positivity.** Leads are not t -positive (Example 9.8), so no “ t -count of minimal flows” can hold. Is there a signed or cancellation-free model?
- (5) **Cumulant link.** Is there a Macdonald-cumulant construction whose leads are the $\star$ -leads for all t , i.e. cumulants of $e_k \mapsto t^{\binom{k}{2}}$?

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